

levels of representation in parliament and cabinet position. From 2009 to 2013 Iceland's prime minister was Jóhanna Sigurðardóttir—the world's first openly LGBT head of state.

To date, the most senior position in the US government held by a woman is Secretary of State, held by Madeleine Albright (see pp. 288–291) from 1997–2001, Condoleezza Rice from 2005–2009, and Hillary Clinton from 2009–2013. In addition, Sandra Day O'Connor was appointed to the Supreme Court in 1981; since then, there have been three female justices in the highest US court.

Money and industry

The growing power of women is not limited to politics; women now hold positions as CEOs, entrepreneurs, and business leaders. Women—such as Mary Barra of General Motors, IBM's Ginni Rometty, and YouTube's Susan Wojcicki—have led some of the world's major international corporations. However, women are still underrepresented in the highest echelons of industry, particularly in the energy, financial, and technology sectors. For example, a 2017 study found that among the 500 largest US corporations, just 6.4 percent of them had female CEOs. Disparity also remains on the Forbes “Rich List”—most of the names are male—but some of the richest people alive are women, including self-made billionaire and media mogul Oprah Winfrey.

▼ Setting an example

Licia Ronzulli, an Italian Member of the European Parliament between 2009 and 2014, took her daughter, Vittoria, to plenary sessions for two years. Vittoria is shown here “voting” alongside her mother at a session in Strasbourg, France, on November 19, 2013.



PROFILES

POWER PLAYERS

Golda Meir (1898–1978) was born in Kiev, but migrated to the US with her family in 1906. She became involved in the Socialist Zionist movement and, in 1921, moved to Palestine, where, in 1948, she was a signatory of Israel's declaration of independence. She was elected to the Israeli parliament in 1949, serving as Minister of Labour, then Foreign Minister. Following the death of the Prime Minister in 1969, Meir took the office, leading her country through the Yom Kippur War before resigning in 1974.

Ruth Bader Ginsberg (b. 1933) was initially a law professor, and was cofounder of the Women's Rights Project at the American Civil Liberties Union, which took six landmark gender discrimination cases to the Supreme Court. In 1993, she was nominated to the Court herself, and has served as a Supreme Court Justice for more than 25 years, writing many liberal decisions and dissents.

Angela Merkel (b. 1954) started her career as a research scientist in East Germany, gaining a doctorate in quantum chemistry in 1986. After the fall of the Berlin Wall in 1989, she became involved in politics, and was elected to parliament during the first elections after German reunification. She became leader of her party in 2000, and in 2005 became the first female chancellor in German history.

Indra Nooyi (b. 1955) grew up in Chennai in southern India and moved to the US in 1978 to attend business school at Yale. In 1994, she joined PepsiCo, a multinational food and beverage corporation. Nooyi rose to become PepsiCo's Chief Financial Officer in 2001, CEO in 2006, and in 2007 took up the position of the company's chair. Nooyi oversaw huge increases in PepsiCo's profits before her resignation in 2018.

Sheryl Sandberg (b. 1969) began her career working for the US Secretary of the Treasury in 1996 but left to work in Silicon Valley in 2001. Her first job there was at the technological giant Google, where she stayed until 2008 before becoming the Chief Operating Officer of Facebook. In 2013, Sandberg published her book *Lean In: Women, Work, and the Will to Lead*, which discusses how women can take a more active role in the business world.